



Finding solidarity in poetry: Celebrating Pittsburgh's young poets on King's day

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Reflecting on her appointment as the nation's 24th Poet Laureate, Ada Limón commented, "I think that it's really important to remember that even in this particularly hard moment, divided moment, poetry can really help us reclaim our humanity." Indeed, reclamation — expressed through the voices of five student poets — took center stage Monday night as City of Asylum Pittsburgh hosted Youth, Poetry, & Activism.

Moderated by the dynamic Danielle Obisie-Orlu, who previously served as Allegheny County Youth Poet Laureate and is currently enrolled at the University of Pittsburgh, the 90-minute program featured readings by Youth Poet Ambassadors Audrey Alling, 17, Jade Davis, 19, Aja Lynn, 17, and Emily Tea, 15 — and current Youth Poet Laureate of Allegheny County Rho Bloom-Wang, 16.

Founded in 2020 by City of Asylum in partnership with the national organization Urban Word, the Local Youth Poet Laureate and Ambassador

program celebrates student voices, artistic excellence and civic engagement while impacting social change.

Tasked with responding to inspirational quotes by activists, the students recited poems invoking the spirits of Ruth Bader Ginsberg, Grace Lee Boggs and Audre Lorde. It was fitting then that 19-year-old Jade Davis selected a quote by Martin Luther King Jr. on the holiday commemorating the civil rights icon's birthday. Turning the "I Have A Dream" speech on its head, Davis writes in "Protect His Legacy":

What's an American Dream?

*Without realizing the
brokenness of our country! ...*

Followers of ignorance

*will always drink the potion
of ambiguity*

*It soothes white guilt with
every swig*

*Be the megaphone, of the
deceased,*

*Because being Black is not
to be perceived as a dangerous weapon,*

but a resurrection of freedom ...

The poetry portion of the evening concluded with the poignant reading of "What It Means To Breathe" by 16-year-old Youth Poet Laureate Rho Bloom-Wang. Exhibiting an exceptional ear ("lungs crimped shut & throats cracked with croup" and "carcinogens creeping into baby skin"), Bloom-Wang addresses with searing directness the dire concerns of their generation — from Black Lives Matter and anti-trans legislation to the inequities of environmental justice: "If they're crushing coal in your backyard / don't you deserve some of the diamonds?"

Following the readings, the five poets were joined on stage by Obisie-Orlu in a discussion that ranged in topics from inspiration and audience to vulnerability and activism. Audience members — in person and online —

offered questions about craft and process, as well as the students' future career goals as writers.

In the spirit of activist poets from prior generations, these young writers are not waiting for gatekeepers to open doors or to give them a platform to express and share their stories, but are using social media to publish or are creating their own spaces to perform. For example, Jade Davis posts weekly poems on the Instagram account @yumyumpoetry, and Hampton High School seniors Aja Lynn and Audrey Alling have founded "Showcase Club" in response to the lack of performance venues that feature student voices.

In these spaces, the writers cultivate a sense of belonging and connection — a theme woven throughout the evening's conversation. "Something that I love about this community," said Winchester Thurston sophomore Emily Tea, "you are not alone."

The power of solidarity, of mobilizing in critical mass, has been a hallmark of protest poetry over the last century. For these writers coming of age in an unprecedented time of COVID-19, #metoo and BLM among the myriad of social issues straining and stretching the country, these creative spaces are a vital place to express and feel heard amidst the cacophony of influencers and media personalities.

"It's really important to show yourself to the world," said Bloom-Wang, "because if you're someone who isn't represented a lot, then there's no doubt that sharing your story is going to connect with someone else and make them feel seen."

To be seen and heard and to speak one's truth make possible human connection and thus the reclamation of shared humanity, and for this, poetry is essential.

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